Lesson 1 · Poetry: "The Poet", from *A Midsummer Night's Dream*

Grade 11 English Home Language · Literature: poetry · Truth, imagination and meaning-making

This is the lesson observed by my University of Pretoria mentor lecturer in August 2026 (98 out of 100).

Grade and subject	Grade 11, English Home Language
Curriculum context	CAPS English Home Language, FET Phase, p. 25: Literature teaching, poetry. Annual Teaching Plan Term 3, Week 7. Text: "The Poet", Theseus's speech from *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, Act 5 Scene 1 (William Shakespeare).
Duration	45 minutes (one period)
Language skills	Reading and viewing; listening and speaking; writing (group answers recorded during the quiz)
Teaching strategies	Cooperative learning, game-based learning, inquiry-based instruction, discovery learning, modelling and scaffolding, guided practice, peer teaching, differentiated instruction
Cross-curricular links	Life Orientation (psychology of identity, imagination and meaning-making); History (ancient Athenian rationality and folklore)
Technology	Deliberately excluded for this lesson, to encourage engagement, group-based problem-solving and traditional whiteboard foundation building.
Taught	Abbotts College Pretoria East, 28 August 2026, five Grade 11 classes

Learning outcomes

By the end of the lesson, learners will be able to critically evaluate and respond to poetry, fulfilling the CAPS requirement to identify how language choices shape meaning. Learners will grasp the concept of poiesis and the limits of imagination, connecting these philosophical dilemmas directly to how they navigate truth, meaning-making and identity in their own lives.

- **Skills:** rapid identification and explanation of poetic devices under time pressure, as well as close textual analysis.
- **Knowledge:** understanding poiesis (meaning-making) and literary terminology (oxymoron, paradox, antithesis); connecting multiple texts.
- **Values and attitudes:** appreciating poetry as an act of hospitality; appreciating tensions between objective reality and human imagination.

Theme and key concepts

Truth, imagination and meaning-making. This links to the learners' real world by providing a cognitive framework to understand how they construct their own realities through the language, stories and media they consume.

- **Poiesis:** originally "making"; here, the most unmediated forms of deliberate meaning-making we possess (speech and acting).
- **Xenia:** the Greek concept of hospitality, framed here as the poet inviting readers to share in a human experience.
- **Residue:** the physical or emotional legacy left behind; a visceral remembrance.
- **Oxymoron:** two seemingly contradictory words placed together (for example "fine frenzy").
- **Paradox:** a statement that appears contradictory but reveals a deeper truth.
- **Antithesis:** contrasting ideas placed in parallel grammatical structures.

Learning and teaching support materials

- Whiteboard and markers, with the clue key written up for the quiz
- Printed and annotated copies of the poem for learners
- **LTSM 1 (original):** my lesson notes for "The Poet": plot context, the clue key for the device hunt, the thought experiments and the discussion questions. Download (PDF)

Lesson sequence

Stage	Time	What happens
Hook	5 min	"Poiesis" is written on the board before the learners walk in. I grab attention and set the room at ease by announcing a much-needed break from their current stressful cycle of assessments: we are simply going to study a beautiful and fascinating poem. One learner reads the text aloud, then I read it once for rhythm. Gut reactions: do you like it, and what do you think it is actually about? Then the context, zooming out to the plot of *A Midsummer Night's Dream*: four Athenian teenagers flee into the woods, a night of fairy magic and hallucinatory chaos, and in the morning Theseus, the voice of strict rationality, dismisses their story, lumping the poet together with the lover and the lunatic.
Introduction: the quiz	10 min	We immediately enter a time-crunch quiz to activate prior knowledge. Learners work in groups to identify and explain as many poetic devices in the poem as they can, building on what they have been practising in previous weeks. A clue key on the board directs them to find two devices every few lines (lines 1–2, 3–5, 6–7, 8–11). "Enjambment" in lines 1–2 is announced as a freebie to break the ice and trigger immediate writing. Answers and scores are held back to build anticipation.
Body	15 min	I discuss the meaning and context of the poem and introduce poiesis. The "skateboarding giraffe" thought experiment shows how speech bypasses reality to conjure up the imagination: everyday magic that forces an image into someone else's brain. We conduct a line-by-line textual analysis by checking the teams' quiz scores and eliciting the held-back answers directly from the learners: alliteration and consonance, hyperbole and contrast, oxymoron and antithesis, personification and paradox. I field clarifying questions on the nuances of the poem and its devices.
Consolidation	15 min	I tie together the syllabus themes of xenia (the poet's hospitality in giving "a local habitation and a name" to "airy nothing") and residue, connecting the poem to "For Oom Piet" and "The Herb Garden". The "square triangle" thought experiment exposes the limits of imagination, and I present the truth-versus-imagination dilemma: would you want to be able always to tell if someone is lying to you, if it cost you your imagination? Vote and argue; both sides are flawed. We end on open discussion: are you a poem or a textbook? Is knowing yourself an art or a science? The discussion is cut right before the bell: whether you discover or create yourself, the only tragedy is passivity. Synthesising themes over multiple texts and identifying poetic devices under pressure prepares learners for unseen poetry.

Learner participation

Learners read the poem aloud, give their gut reactions, and then work in competitive groups on the device hunt, recording their group's answers against the clue key. In the body of the lesson they supply the held-back answers themselves, ask clarifying questions and receive individual attention in the ensuing discussion. In the consolidation they vote on the dilemma, argue for a side, and debate the closing questions about identity in open discussion.

Differentiation

The device hunt is scaffolded so that every learner can contribute: the clue key narrows each search to a few lines and names how many devices to find, the freebie gives weaker groups an immediate first answer, and mixed groups let stronger readers model the explanation of a device for the others. Answers are scored per correct device, so partial success counts. The thought experiments and the dilemma give learners who struggle with abstract terminology a concrete way in, while the open discussion lets stronger learners stretch into the philosophical layer of the poem. Technology is left out so that no learner is disadvantaged by access to a device.

PLACEHOLDER Differentiation paragraph drafted from the strategies and notes in Wehan's WIL plan. Wehan to confirm or adjust.

Assessment opportunities

SMART task, informal and formative. Groups must identify poetic devices based on line ranges using the clue key on the board. Their answers are then scored objectively per correct device, in line with the CAPS figures-of-speech outcomes, with "enjambment" given as a freebie to build momentum. Group answers are recorded and checked during the line-by-line analysis, which also tells me which devices need another pass before the unseen-poetry assessment.

Reflection after teaching

Framing the lesson as a break from assessments worked well to gain learner buy-in. The initial time-crunch quiz created good engagement. Overall, synthesising concepts across the syllabus was effective, though pacing was a challenge across the different sessions, which caused the consistency of the lesson delivery to waver a bit, but to no real ill effect. They struggled with the abstract elements, but they resonated strongly with the connections between the three poems. No re-teaching is necessary in my opinion.

Alignment. In line with English HL FET CAPS, a text-based and communicative approach was maintained. Poetic devices were not taught in isolation; they were integrated directly into the thematic discussion to develop critical analytical skills for unseen poetry and build critical language awareness.

References

- Department of Basic Education. (2011). *Curriculum and Assessment Policy Statement (CAPS): English Home Language Grades 10–12*. Government Printing Works.
- Shakespeare, W. (2008). *A Midsummer Night's Dream* (P. Holland, Ed.). Oxford University Press. (Original work published 1600)

PLACEHOLDER Wehan to confirm the poetry anthology the school uses for "The Poet", so the reference matches it.